

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN BURKINA FASO

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Concern for the environment in Burkina Faso turns above all on gold and on the land — for this is a landlocked Sahelian nation, a military-led state gripped by insecurity across much of its territory, whose economy has shifted in a generation from the land to gold, and whose defining environmental struggles are the harms of a gold-mining boom and the advance of the desert upon the farms. Burkina Faso is a country of dryland and gold pit and cotton field, of a fierce sun and a fragile soil, where hundreds of thousands now dig for gold to survive, where mercury and cyanide seep into the water and the land, and where, against the encroaching desert, farmers have pioneered some of the world's great feats of land restoration. That reality — a nation of the gold boom and the threatened land, its mining fraught with pollution and insecurity, its soil fought for against the desert — is the distinctive ground of environmental effort here. This guide will treat the cleaning and formalizing of the gold, the sustaining of the cotton and the land, the holding-back of the desert through the proven grassroots restoration, and the stewardship of the water and the trees as Burkina Faso's central environmental work, pursued, in a fraught and insecure nation, through the institutions that still function, the international and regional frameworks, and the communities where it is safe, protecting people, and never punishing those who mine or farm to survive. Burkina Faso is a land of gold and cotton and hard-won soil, Sahelian and fraught and resilient, where the desert has been pushed back by the zai pit and the stone bund, and where the gold that now feeds the nation also poisons its water and entangles its peace. This guide will be honest that the state is military-led and much of the country insecure, so work runs through what functions and with care; that the gold is now the economy and bound up with the insecurity; that the artisanal mining is a survival livelihood that must never be met with mere repression; that the desert and the climate press hard; and that no swift or landmark victory is to be promised; but it will show that the levers here — the gold and the mining, the cotton and the land, the desert and the Green Wall, the water and the trees, and the within-system, international, and community channels — are real, and, as the celebrated land restoration of Burkina's own farmers shows, genuinely usable.

The Burkinabè story teaches two things about defending the environment here, and this guide states both plainly. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever pressed together. The second is distinctly Burkinabè, and it is what gives this guide its particular force. **Because the gold can be cleaned and formalized — never through repression of those who mine to live, but through safer methods and better governance — because the cotton and the land can be sustained, because the desert can be held back through the grassroots restoration Burkina's own farmers pioneered, because the water and the trees can be stewarded, and because the institutions that still function and the international and community channels offer real avenues even a fraught state affords, the levers run through the gold and the land: the gold, the cotton, the desert, the water, and the channels.** That combination — the gold, the cotton, the desert, the water, and the channels — is the distinctive lever here, and this guide is built around it, because in a fraught, insecure, gold-dependent Sahelian nation, the strongest ground is the cleaning of the gold, the sustaining of the land, the holding-back of the desert, and the stewardship of the water, through what functions, the international, and the community, and never punishing the poor.

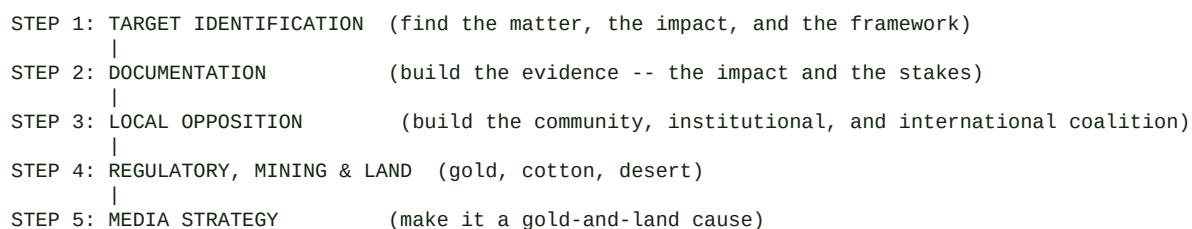
But the same story carries honest qualifications this guide states plainly and takes seriously. **The state is military-led, much of the country insecure, the gold entangled with conflict, the mining a survival livelihood, and no swift victory exists.** The state is military-led and much insecure, so work runs through what functions and with care; the gold is bound up with the insecurity; the artisanal mining must never be met with mere repression; the desert and climate press; and no swift or landmark victory is to be promised. This guide does not pretend the state is secure, or that the gold is easily challenged, or that those who mine to survive are to blame. What it shows is how, through the gold, the cotton, the desert, the water, and the channels, those who care — the communities, the functioning institutions, the international and regional bodies, and the people where it is safe — can clean the gold, sustain the land, hold back the desert, and steward the water, through what functions and the international, protecting people and never punishing the poor.

Most people who care about Burkina Faso's environment do not know HOW to use the levers a fraught, insecure, gold-dependent Sahelian nation offers. They see the gold pits poison the water, the cotton strain the soil, the desert advance, the trees fall — and either despair of an insecure, military-led state, or overlook the levers that work: the cleaner mining and mercury reduction, the formalization in consultation with miners, the celebrated land restoration, the Great Green Wall, the international and community frameworks. The gap between the land defended and the land lost is here often a gap of method — the method of using the gold, the cotton, the desert, the water, and the channels together, through what functions and never punishing the poor.

This guide shows what can actually be tried — inside the Burkinabè reality as it is, which is a fraught, insecure, gold-dependent Sahelian nation of the gold boom and the threatened land, through the institutions that function, the international, and the community. It is written for the person — in a community of the drylands or the gold fields, among Burkina Faso's environmental and mining institutions, in the international and regional bodies, or among the farmers and miners where it is safe — who sees the poisoned water and the advancing desert and wants to know what can be done in a fraught Sahelian nation. The answer is a qualified yes: the levers are real — the gold and the mining, the cotton and the land, the desert and the Green Wall, the water and the trees, and the channels — with the honest qualifiers that the state is military-led, the country insecure, the gold entangled with conflict, and the mining a survival livelihood, so the work is within-system where it functions, international, community-based, restoration-centred, safe, and never punitive toward the poor.

The Strategic Framework

Effective efforts follow the same underlying pattern, adapted to a fraught, insecure, gold-dependent Sahelian nation:



These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. The evidence of the impact and the stakes feeds the gold cleaning, the land sustaining, and the desert holding-back at once; the community, institutional, and international coalition organises; a mercury reduction, a land restoration, or an international appeal is both a good in itself and a spur to the next. The effort that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, gives itself the best — if still hard-won — chance of cleaning the gold, sustaining the land, and holding back the

desert.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Burkina Faso's — a fraught, insecure, gold-dependent Sahelian nation — give a distinctive set:

- **The gold.** The **gold and the mining** can be cleaned and formalized through safer methods and better governance — never repression — the distinctive lever.
- **The cotton.** The **cotton and the land** can be sustained through pesticide reduction and soil health.
- **The desert.** The **desert** can be held back through the Great Green Wall and the grassroots restoration Burkina pioneered.
- **The water.** The **water and the trees** can be stewarded through water harvesting, reforestation, and agroforestry.
- **The channels.** The **within-system, international, and community channels** offer real avenues even a fraught state affords.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers bring swift victory, or that the state is secure, or that the poor who mine are to blame. The state is **military-led**; the country is **insecure**; the gold is **entangled with conflict**; the mining is a **survival livelihood**; and no swift victory **exists**. This guide takes those limits seriously — it states them plainly, and it works through what functions, the international, and the community, protecting people and never punishing the poor — and shows how to use the real tools this situation offers — the gold, the cotton, the desert, the water, and the channels — to clean the gold and hold back the desert, honestly acknowledging the military-led state, the insecurity, the entangled gold, the survival livelihood, and the absence of a swift victory.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see — and here you must see that the levers run through a fraught but not empty system: the institutions that still function — the environment, mining, and agriculture bodies, the regulators, the research institutes — in a military-led state where much of the country is insecure, together with the international and regional frameworks, the mercury and desertification conventions, and the communities where it is safe, because in a fraught nation there is much that is weak or dangerous, but there is real institutional capacity, real international engagement, and real community life and restoration. Before you spend a single week, map who actually can act on a matter, at which level, and where the leverage is real — and where it is safe. And map where the gold, the cotton, the desert, the water, and the channels apply, because in Burkina Faso a harm is met not by a strong state, but through the functioning institutions, the international frameworks, the celebrated restoration, and the community, protecting people and never punishing the poor.

The Levels of Decision

A Burkinabè environmental effort runs through a fraught state, its functioning institutions, and a wide international and community system.

The functioning institutions. The **environment, mining, and agriculture ministries, the regulators, and the research institutes** retain real capacity where they function, and are where much practical action lies.

The military-led government. The **military-led government and its resource and security interests**, gripped by insecurity and resource-nationalism, shape the mining and the state's writ, so an effort works through what functions and where it is safe.

The international and regional bodies. The **international and regional frameworks — the mercury and desertification conventions, the Great Green Wall, the humanitarian and development partners, and the artisanal-mining bodies** carry much of the leverage a fraught state cannot.

The scientists and researchers. The **environmental, mining, agricultural, and land scientists and research institutes, Burkinabè and international** hold the case for the gold, the land, and the desert.

The community, farmers, and miners. The **communities, the farmers who restore the land, the artisanal miners, and the people where it is safe** hold knowledge, stake, and voice, and can act where it is safe.

The Journey of a Matter

A Burkinabè matter — the gold's mercury and cyanide, the cotton's strain on the soil, the advancing desert, the falling trees and scarce water — is met through the **gold, the cotton, the desert, the water, and the channels. The gold and the desert are where the great questions are decided, and the cotton, the water, and the channels are what carry the effort** — and using them together, through what functions, the international, and the community, is the distinctive Burkinabè approach. The distinctive levers are the **gold**, the **cotton**, the **desert**, the **water**, and the **channels**. Find out exactly what can be done where it is safe, and, crucially, **what water, soil, land, or air is at stake, what mining, environmental, mercury, or desertification framework applies, and how the functioning institutions, the international bodies, and the community can act**, because those are where a matter can genuinely be met — and never punishing those who mine or farm to survive.

Follow the Matter, the Impact, and the Framework

Behind a matter stand the functioning institutions, the military-led government, the international bodies, and the water, soil, land, and air at stake — and, always here, the survival livelihoods bound to the gold and the land. Trace who can act, what is harmed, and — importantly here — **what water, soil, land, or air is impacted, what mining, environmental, mercury, desertification, or land framework applies, what the science shows, and how the functioning institutions, the international bodies, and the community can act, without punishing the poor**. Two questions unlock most Burkinabè efforts: **What is impacted, and what functioning, international, or mercury/desertification framework reaches it?** and **Which lever — the gold, the cotton, the desert, the water, the channels — can carry it, safely and without punishing the poor?** The functioning institutions, the international frameworks, the celebrated restoration, and the community are, together, the heart of most such efforts here.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies and forces that shape a matter, because they are the levers. The **functioning institutions**; the **military-led government**; the **international and regional bodies**; the **scientists and researchers**; and the **community, farmers, and miners**. In Burkina Faso, the **gold, the cotton, the desert, the water, and the channels** are the most distinctive levers. Each is a separate front, and the gold's poison, the cotton's strain, the advancing desert, or the falling trees can genuinely be met — through the functioning institutions, the international frameworks, the restoration, and the community — though, honestly, the state is military-led, the country insecure, and the gold entangled with conflict, and this guide

will keep saying so, and keep working through what functions, the international, and the community, protecting people and never punishing the poor.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit effort, calibrate honestly — and here that means acknowledging the military-led state, the insecurity, and the gold's entanglement with conflict, even as the functioning institutions, the international frameworks, the celebrated restoration, and the community give real, if hard-won, leverage. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how environmental efforts tend to go in fraught, insecure, resource-dependent states, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the matter can be **tied to a functioning institution, a mercury or desertification framework, or the proven restoration**, whether the **community, the institutions, and the international** can be engaged, whether the work can be done **safely**, and whether it **avoids punishing the poor**. Where the effort centres on cleaner mining, land restoration, and the things that help rather than repress, the levers here are real; but temper every figure with the honest knowledge that the state is military-led, the country insecure, and the gold entangled with conflict.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	15–25%	weeks	low	Basis for every other step
Gold: cleaner methods & formalization	25–45%	years	low–moderate	The gold cleaned, mercury cut, miners helped
Cotton / land & pesticides	30–50%	years	low	The cotton and soil sustained
Desert / restoration & Green Wall	45–65%	years	low	The desert held back, land restored
Water / trees & agroforestry	40–60%	years	low	The water and trees stewarded
Community / functioning-institution route	35–55%	years	low	The community and functioning bodies engaged
International / mercury / desertification route	35–55%	years	low	The international frameworks engaged
All levers together	30–55%	years	moderate	Gold cleaned; land and desert restored

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Burkina Faso's real strength is its celebrated land restoration and its functioning institutions and community: the **gold**, the **cotton**, the **desert**, the **water**, and the **channels**. Its constraints are specific and honest: the state is **military-led**, the country **insecure**, the gold **entangled with conflict**, and the mining a **survival livelihood** — but the restoration, the functioning institutions, the international frameworks, and the community make the levers here genuinely usable, and never at the cost of punishing the poor.

A note on cost and risk: the levers centred on restoration, cleaner methods, and helping rather than repressing — a land restoration, a mercury reduction, a soil measure, an international appeal — can be

*pursued through the functioning institutions, the international frameworks, and the communities where it is safe. But the state is military-led and much of the country insecure and dangerous, so the safety of everyone must come first, conflict and armed-group areas must be avoided, and work must run through what functions and with care. And the artisanal mining is a survival livelihood, so the work must never be repression of the poor but the offer of safer, cleaner ways. The scarce resources are **the institutional and international connections, the restoration knowledge, and the community engagement** — much of it reachable through the functioning institutions, the mercury and desertification frameworks, the Great Green Wall, and the communities. And because Burkina's own farmers pioneered world-renowned land restoration, the desert and restoration levers are the most reachable and hopeful.*

Effectiveness Visualization

GOLD + COTTON + DESERT + WATER + CHANNELS:
 Desert / restoration & Green Wall: ██████████ 45-65%
 Water / trees & agroforestry: ██████████ 40-60%
 Community / functioning-institution route: ██████████ 35-55%
 International / mercury / desertification: ██████████ 35-55%
 Cotton / land & pesticides: ██████████ 30-50%

MILITARY-LED / INSECURE / GOLD-ENTANGLED -- harder ground:
 Repressing those who mine to live: ██ wrong and backfires
 Restoration, cleaner methods & the international: ██████████ the real path
 Gold cleaned, desert held back: ██████████ achievable in part
 The impact and stakes documented: ██████████ the reliable foundation

How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in Burkina Faso are **the desert restoration and Green Wall, the water and trees, the community and functioning-institution route, and the international frameworks** — used together, with the gold and cotton efforts alongside. The restoration, water, and community levers show the ceiling, which is genuinely hopeful: the celebrated grassroots restoration, the agroforestry, and the community achieve real gains, as Burkina's own farmers have shown the world. The military-led state, the insecurity, and the gold's entanglement show the honest floor: the state is fraught, much is dangerous, and the gold is bound up with conflict and survival. Most Burkinabè efforts will sit between, and the honest lesson is that the levers here are real — able to clean the gold and hold back the desert in part — but that repressing those who mine to live is wrong and backfires, and the surest result is that the impact is documented and pressed through the restoration, the functioning institutions, the international, and the community.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **The desert restoration and the community** — Burkina Faso's distinctive levers; the world-renowned grassroots land restoration and the people who carry it.
2. **The water, trees, and Green Wall** — the stewardship of the soil, water, and land against the desert.
3. **The gold cleaned and formalized, never repressed** — the mercury cut and the miners helped, not punished.
4. **The cotton and soil and the international frameworks** — the sustaining of the land and the leverage of the conventions.
5. **The documented impact and stakes** — the evidence that grounds it all.

What These Campaigns Actually Show

A few honest patterns recur. **Burkina's farmers pioneered world-renowned restoration** — the zaï pit and the stone bund that bring dead land to life. **The gold is now the economy** — and entangled with pollution

and insecurity. **The mining is a survival livelihood** — never to be met with mere repression. **The desert can be held back** — by the proven grassroots techniques and the Great Green Wall. **And the state is fraught** — so the work is through what functions and the community, and safely. The through-line: **document the impact and the stakes; clean and formalize the gold through safer methods and better governance, never repression; sustain the cotton and the land; hold back the desert through the grassroots restoration and the Green Wall; steward the water and the trees; use the functioning institutions, the international, and the community; and protect people and never punish the poor** — because an effort that does can genuinely clean the gold and hold back the desert in part, while being honest that the state is military-led, the country insecure, and the gold entangled with conflict.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective effort begins by finding the exact matter — and the leverage, which here runs through the functioning institutions, the international frameworks, the celebrated restoration, and the community. Vague concern goes nowhere, and repression of the poor is wrong and counterproductive; an effort aimed at "this matter impacting this water, soil, land, or air, which a functioning institution, a mercury or desertification framework, or the proven restoration can reach, carried by the institutions, the international, or the community, without punishing the poor" is a real, workable effort. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

- 1. What is impacted?** This is the first question here. What **water, soil, land, or air** is impacted — the mercury- or cyanide-poisoned water, the strained cotton soil, the advancing desert, the falling trees.
- 2. What framework reaches it?** What **mining, environmental, mercury, desertification, or land framework** reaches the impact — the mining and environmental rules, the mercury convention, the desertification and Great Green Wall frameworks, the restoration.
- 3. Is it the gold, the cotton, or the desert?** Whether the matter is one of the **gold and mining, the cotton and land, or the desert and restoration** — for each has its levers.
- 4. What framework, safety, and livelihood apply?** What **framework** applies, **how safe is the work**, and **what livelihood** is bound to it, for the country is insecure and the mining a survival trade.
- 5. How can the institutions, international, and community act, safely and without punishing the poor?** How the **functioning institutions, the international bodies, and the community** can act — where it is safe, protecting people, and never punishing those who mine or farm to survive.

A Worked Example

Suppose an artisanal gold site is poisoning a community's water with mercury and cyanide — the contamination spreading to the wells and the fields — even as hundreds of people, with no other livelihood, depend on that site to survive, and armed groups are not far off.

Working the five questions: **what is impacted? What framework reaches it? Is it the gold, the cotton, or the desert? What framework, safety, and livelihood apply?** And how can the institutions, international, and community act, safely and without punishing the poor? The driver is the mercury and cyanide contamination and the survival livelihood, with the cleaner methods, the mercury reduction, the formalization, and the health monitoring as the levers — never the mere closure that would ruin the poor and hand the armed groups a grievance.

Within a season the effort has moved from "the site is poisoning us but the people need it" to a real, careful effort: document the mercury and cyanide contamination and the health risk; press, through the functioning institutions and the mercury framework, for the cleaner and safer methods, the mercury reduction, and the health monitoring that protect both the water and the miners' livelihood; advance the formalization in genuine consultation with the miners, not their repression; and engage the international and community — all through what functions, where it is safe, and never punishing the poor. That is a workable effort suited to Burkina Faso — one that cleans the gold and protects the water through cleaner methods and consultation, not repression. Notice what the five questions accomplish, and how they suit a fight in a fraught, insecure, gold-dependent Sahelian nation: they turn what might seem an impossible tangle — a poisoning livelihood, a dangerous countryside, an entangled gold, an advancing desert — into a set of specific, answerable questions, each attached to a lever that rests on the functioning institutions, the international frameworks, the celebrated restoration, and the community, and each honouring the twin imperatives of safety and justice toward the poor rather than despairing at the insecurity or reaching for the repression that backfires. The impact becomes a documentable contamination, degradation, or strain. The framework becomes the functioning institution, the mercury or desertification convention, or the proven restoration that reaches it. The category becomes the gold, the cotton, or the desert, each with its levers. The framework becomes the cleaner-methods, formalization, and restoration process, the safety the country's insecurity demands, and the justice the poor deserve. And the channels become the functioning institutions, the international, and the community, where it is safe. That translation — from an impossible tangle into a set of specific, restorative, safe, and just actions — is the first and most important thing a Burkinabè effort does, because it moves the fight from despair at a fraught state onto the firm ground of the restoration and the cleaner methods and the community, where real cleaning and restoring are genuinely possible without ever endangering a person or punishing the poor.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on — and here a clear record of the impact and the stakes is what moves the functioning institutions, the international frameworks, and the community. An institution, an international body, a research institute, and the community all move on evidence — and for Burkina Faso, a clear record of the impact and the stakes of what is threatened, together with an honest account of the livelihoods, is precisely what a within-system and international effort turns into a real result, so build it well, and safely. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Matter, the Impact, and the Framework

Get the facts the effort turns on. Identify the **matter and the impact** — the gold's poison, the cotton's strain, the advancing desert, the falling trees — and, decisively here, **the water, soil, land, or air it impacts and the framework that reaches it**: the mining and environmental rules, the mercury and desertification frameworks, the restoration. And note honestly **the livelihoods bound to it**. Establish exactly **what is threatened, what it impacts, and what framework reaches it**, because the impact-against-the-framework, weighed with livelihood, is the effort's foundation.

Layer 2: The Impact, the Science, and the Stakes

Document the impact with the science. Establish the **environmental impact** — the mercury and cyanide contamination, the soil and water harm, the desertification and land degradation, the deforestation — and its **stakes** — drawing on **the mining, environmental, and land science, the mercury and cyanide and**

health studies, the desertification and restoration data, and, where safe, community knowledge. This impact-and-stakes evidence, grounded in the documented pollution and the celebrated restoration, turns the concern into a documented case the functioning institutions, the international, and the community will act on.

Layer 3: The Case, the Framework, the Channel, the Safety, and the Livelihood

Finally, document the case and the path. Does the **impact** threaten a water source, a soil, a land, or a health? What **framework** — mining, environmental, mercury, desertification — applies? Which **institution, international, or community channel** will carry it? How will everyone be **kept safe**, and how will the effort **avoid punishing the poor**? Each is a separate element, and together they make a case the channels can act on — safely and justly. This is the layer that most often decides these efforts, because a documented impact, an applicable framework, a channel, a safe path, and a livelihood honestly reckoned with are exactly what let a Burkinabè effort clean the gold and hold back the desert. Build it well, and the gold, the cotton, the desert, the water, and the channels become the effort's genuine strength.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Evidence in hand beats evidence you assume exists — and here much of it lives in the research and environmental records, the mercury and pollution studies, the desertification and restoration data, and the knowledge of the farmers and communities where it is safe. Here is where the material tends to live in a Burkinabè effort, and how to get it — with the **impact**, the **stakes**, the **framework**, the **safety**, and the **livelihood** at the center. Treat this as a checklist to work through, not a menu to admire.

The Matter and Framework Record

Start with the matter and the framework. **The mining, permit, and environmental records, the research and pollution studies, and the regulatory records** establish the matter and the impact; the distinctive strengths here are the **mercury and desertification frameworks and the Great Green Wall** and the **research institutes and the celebrated restoration knowledge**. Establish the **matter, the impact, and the framework that reaches it**, and honestly **the livelihood bound to it**, drawing on the mining, research, and environmental records. Establish exactly **what is threatened, what it impacts, and what framework reaches it**, because a matter reachable through a functioning institution, the mercury framework, or the proven restoration is strong ground in a fraught state.

The Impact, Science, and Stakes Evidence

This is the heart of the file. Gather the **impact evidence** — the mercury and cyanide contamination, the soil and water harm, the desertification and land degradation, the deforestation — and the **science and the stakes** — drawing on **the mining, environmental, and land science, the mercury and cyanide and health studies, the desertification and restoration data, the satellite and research reports, and, where safe, community and farmer knowledge**. Burkina Faso's gold pollution and its land restoration are both increasingly studied by its research institutes and international partners, so much of this evidence exists; marshalling it is what turns the concern into a documented, actionable case.

The Framework, Institutional, and International Record

Document the levers of the frameworks. Gather the record of **the environment, mining, and agriculture institutions and the research institutes; the mercury and desertification conventions, the Great Green Wall, and the artisanal-mining and formalization frameworks; and the restoration programmes and the international and humanitarian partners**. A community and its allies that understand the mercury

framework, the desertification and Green Wall frameworks, and the celebrated restoration hold the levers that clean the gold and hold back the desert in a fraught state.

The Community, Farmer, and Scientific Record

Document the wider levers. Gather the record of the **communities, the farmers who restore the land, and the artisanal miners where it is safe**; the **environmental, mining, agricultural, and land scientists and research institutes, Burkinabè and international**; and the **international, regional, and restoration networks**. A community and its allies joined to the farmers, the miners, the scientists, and the international bodies hold levers that reach a fraught nation where its weak state cannot — and the farmers who pioneered the restoration are themselves a source of world-renowned knowledge.

The People, the Safety, the Livelihood, and the Stakes

Finally, and most importantly, map the human terrain, the safety, and the livelihoods. Who is affected — the **communities, the farmers, the artisanal miners, the water-users, and the future generations** — and who can act safely: the **communities where it is safe, the functioning institutions, the international bodies, and the farmers and restorers**, since the country is insecure and the mining a survival trade. And how does the effort **protect everyone, avoid the dangerous areas, and never punish those who mine or farm to survive**? A Burkinabè effort is advanced through the gold, the cotton, the desert, the water, and the channels — so map that coalition deliberately, centre on the safe and the restorative, let the safety of everyone govern every step, and never make the poor the target, for repression of those who mine to live is both unjust and self-defeating.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Here this step must be understood in the light of a fraught, insecure, military-led state, where the government is fraught and much of the country dangerous, and where adversarial confrontation — and above all any targeting of the poor who mine — is unwise and unjust, but where the communities endure, the farmers restore the land with world-renowned skill, and real institutions and international engagement remain, so the "opposition" that works is the constructive coalition of the communities and farmers, the functioning institutions, and the international bodies, centred on the safe, the restorative, and the just, and never punishing the poor. The task is to build a coalition — of communities, farmers, functioning institutions, and international bodies — that cleans the gold, sustains the land, and holds back the desert, safely and justly.

Why the Community-Farmer-Institution-and-International Coalition Is Decisive

In Burkina Faso, the coalition that can act joins the communities and farmers to the functioning institutions and the international bodies, because a fraught state cannot lead strong action, but the communities and farmers restore the land, the functioning institutions retain real capacity, and the international frameworks carry the mercury and desertification leverage. That coalition supplies what an effort runs on: the communities and farmers who hold the stake, the knowledge, and the celebrated restoration skill, the functioning institutions with their real capacity, the international and regional bodies that carry the frameworks, the scientists whose evidence grows, and the justice of a cause that helps rather than punishes the poor. When the communities, the farmers, the functioning institutions, and the international bodies act together, safely, they become a genuine force — as the grassroots restoration that pushed back the desert has shown. **A coalition that is community-based, farmer-led, institution-engaged, and internationally supported here, safe and just, is not a weaker substitute for a strong state; it is the effective form**

defence takes in a fraught one, working through what functions and the restoration Burkina's own people pioneered — the real foundation of a Burkinabè effort, cleaning the gold and holding back the desert, while people are protected and the poor are never punished.

Finding the Coalition

Begin not with confrontation or the targeting of the poor, but with those who can act safely and justly — the **communities and farmers where it is safe, the functioning institutions, the international and regional bodies, and the artisanal miners themselves** — and protect everyone. Widen to the wider international, restoration, and humanitarian networks that share the stake in Burkina's land. Name the shared stake — **our water, our soil, our land, and the desert our own farmers have shown can be pushed back** — because Burkina's land and water are a stake shared across communities and with a world that admires its restoration. Frame the effort around cleaning the gold and restoring the land, through what functions, the restoration, and the international, safely and justly.

Coalition-Building, Through Community, Farmer, Institution, and International

A coalition allied is stronger than any single actor, and for Burkina Faso it is built through the community, the farmers, the institutions, and the international. Reach to the **communities and farmers where it is safe; the artisanal miners, engaged not repressed; the functioning environment, mining, and agriculture institutions; the international, regional, and mercury and desertification bodies; and the scientists, research institutes, and restoration networks**. Frame the coalition around the gold, the cotton, the desert, and the water. Build breadth through the community, the farmers, the institutions, and the international, protect everyone, and never punish the poor — for the coalition's strength is precisely that it centres on the restoration, the functioning, and the just, and reaches the international frameworks a fraught state needs.

Sustaining the Effort

Burkinabè efforts are sustained through the community, the farmers, the institutions, and the international. Keep the coalition **connected, supported, safe, and just**, and centred on the restoration and the helping; mark real steps — a mercury reduction won, a site formalized in consultation, a soil restored, a Green Wall stretch advanced, a forest replanted. And keep the effort grounded in the shared land and water, the celebrated restoration, and the justice of helping rather than punishing the poor. The effort that lasts is the one that joins the community and farmers to the institutions and the international, centres on the safe and the restorative, protects everyone, and never punishes the poor.

STEP 4: REGULATORY, MINING & LAND CHALLENGES — THE GOLD, THE COTTON, AND THE DESERT

This is where a Burkinabè effort is realistically advanced — not through a strong state, which does not exist, but through the **cleaning and formalizing of the gold, the sustaining of the cotton and the land, and the holding-back of the desert** — carried through what functions, the international, and the community, safely and never punishing the poor. Here the gold, cotton, and desert levers come together, because in Burkina Faso a matter can be met through the functioning institutions, the mercury and desertification frameworks, the celebrated restoration, and the community — where it is safe.

Setting Expectations Honestly

First, the honest truth. The levers are **real but the state fraught, the gold entangled, and the restoration the brightest hope**. The gold cleaning is **real through safer methods and formalization, though the**

gold is the economy and bound up with insecurity, and repression of the poor is wrong and self-defeating; the cotton and land sustaining is **genuine**; the desert holding-back is **the brightest and most proven lever, through the restoration Burkina's own farmers pioneered**; and the state is **fraught**. What these levers realistically achieve is **the gold cleaned and the mercury cut and the miners helped, the cotton and soil sustained, the desert held back and the land restored, and the water and trees stewarded** — real, if partial, outcomes centred on the restoration and the functioning, in a fraught state, and never at the cost of the poor. Enter this front clear-eyed: the gold, the cotton, and the desert are Burkina Faso's distinctive levers, strongest when centred on **the restoration, the cleaner methods, and the helping rather than the repressing** — but the state is fraught and the gold entangled.

The Gold and the Mining

The first front is the gold. The **gold-mining boom — the industrial mines and the artisanal rush that now feeds the nation and sustains hundreds of thousands, with its mercury and cyanide contamination, its land degradation, and its fraught entanglement with the region's insecurity** can be cleaned and formalized through **the cleaner and safer methods, the mercury and cyanide reduction, the health monitoring, and the formalization and better governance pursued in genuine consultation with the miners** — never through the mere repression or closure that ruins the poor and hands the armed groups a grievance — together with the environmental standards for the industrial mines and the international mercury framework. Use the gold and the mining, because the gold is now the economy and a survival livelihood for hundreds of thousands, so it can never be met with blame or mere closure — the pits will not vanish while the poor must eat, and repression only feeds the very insecurity it claims to fight — and the only real and just answer is to clean it: to reduce the mercury and cyanide through safer methods, to monitor the health, to formalize in genuine consultation with the miners, and to hold the industrial mines to environmental standards, so that the gold and the people are both served.

The Cotton and the Land

The second front is the cotton and the land. The **cotton — the historic "white gold" and still a major crop and smallholder livelihood — with its pesticide, soil, and water strains, and the wider farmland** can be sustained through **the pesticide reduction and integrated pest management, the soil health and sustainable agriculture, and the support for the smallholder farmers**. Use the cotton and the land, because cotton remains a livelihood for many smallholders and a strain on the soil and water, so sustaining it means reducing the pesticides, restoring the soil, and supporting the farmers toward a more sustainable cultivation — protecting both the land and the livelihood that the crop provides.

The Desert, the Restoration, and the Green Wall

The third front, and the brightest, is the desert and the restoration. The **advancing desert and the degraded land — the desertification, the drought, the land degradation of the Sahel** can be held back through **the celebrated grassroots restoration Burkina's own farmers pioneered — the zaï planting pits, the stone bunds and half-moons, the farmer-managed natural regeneration that have brought tens of thousands of hectares of dead land back to life — together with the Great Green Wall and the reforestation and agroforestry**. Press the desert, the restoration, and the Green Wall, because Burkina Faso is home to some of the world's most celebrated land restoration — the zaï pit and the stone bund by which its own farmers turned barren, crusted ground back into cropland and forest, an achievement admired the world over — so holding back the desert is not a distant hope but a proven, grassroots, low-cost practice to be spread and sustained, joined to the Great Green Wall and the agroforestry, so that the land degraded by drought and pressure is restored by the very people who live on it. There is a distinctive and hopeful

power in this restoration front that sets Burkina Faso apart, and it deserves to be understood fully. In most of the guides in this series, the levers are ways to stop or mitigate a harm imposed from outside or above; here, uniquely, the central hope is a proven, positive practice that Burkina's own farmers invented or revived and that belongs to the communities themselves — the zaï, the shallow planting pits dug into crusted, abandoned land and filled with manure that draws termites to break the soil and hold the water, and the cordons pierreux, the lines of stones laid along the contour that slow the runoff and let it soak in — techniques so effective that they have brought tens of thousands of hectares of dead land back into cropland and forest, and so admired that they are studied and copied across the Sahel and beyond. This matters enormously for a fraught state, because such restoration needs no strong government, no large budget, and no security that the country cannot provide: it needs seeds, stones, labour, and knowledge the communities already hold. Using this front well means spreading and sustaining that grassroots restoration — supporting the farmers who practise it, joining it to the Great Green Wall and the agroforestry, and protecting the knowledge as the national treasure it is — so that the single brightest and most autonomous lever Burkina Faso holds is carried as far as the degraded land extends. Pursued together — the gold, the cotton, and the desert — these fronts are how a Burkinabè effort cleans the gold, sustains the land, and holds back the desert, through the functioning institutions, the international, the restoration, and the community, safely and never punishing the poor.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Evidence does not speak for itself; you must aim it at each partner in the language that moves them. The same file of impact and stakes becomes different arguments for the functioning institutions, the international bodies, the community and farmers, the miners, and the scientists. Translate deliberately, and always safely, justly, and never punishing the poor.

For the Functioning Institutions

The functioning institutions respond to **the mandate, the manageable, and the state's own aims**. Frame the matter as a manageable one within their remit, aligned even with the state's own formalization and resource aims: here is the contamination, the cleaner method or restoration, the formalization within your mandate. Give them the documented impact and the case, and press for the mercury reduction, the formalization in consultation, the restoration. Make it concrete: *here is the poisoned water and the health risk, here is the cleaner method and the formalization that serve both the gold and the people*. This is the argument a functioning institution can act on.

For the International and Mercury/Desertification Frameworks

The international and mercury and desertification frameworks respond to **the frameworks, the standards, and the stakes**. Frame the matter as one their conventions and programmes reach: here is the mercury or cyanide, the desertification, the frameworks and support you can bring. Give them the case, and press for the mercury reduction, the restoration support, the desertification and Green Wall frameworks. An international body or convention seized of the mercury or the desert can act where the fraught state cannot alone.

For the Community, Farmers, and Miners

The community, farmers, and miners respond to **the water, the land, the livelihood, and the restoration**. Translate the file into the story of a poisoned water, a threatened soil, and a livelihood to be protected, not punished: here is the contamination, the cleaner method that protects your health and your trade, the

restoration that brings the land back. Frame it as the defence of the community's water and land and the protection of its livelihood. Keep it accurate, safe, and just; and speak to the community's stake in its own water, land, and living — and never as a threat to the poor.

For the Scientists and Restorers

The scientists and restorers respond to **the evidence and the restoration**. Frame the matter as one their science and their restoration knowledge can meet: here is the contamination, the degradation, the evidence and the proven restoration. Give them the case, and press for the documentation, the monitoring, and the spread of the restoration. Burkina's own restorers hold world-renowned knowledge; its scientists document the harm.

The Golden Rule

Never fabricate, never exaggerate, centre on the restorative and the just, protect everyone, and never punish the poor. Your credibility rests on the real impact and the real stakes — the functioning, international, and community case, safe, just, and centred on helping rather than repressing; and the safety of everyone and the justice toward the poor are paramount. State the impact precisely, tie it to the gold, the cotton, or the desert, and press through the functioning institutions, the international, the community, and the restorers. An effort that is precise, restorative, safe, and just is far more effective than one that overreaches, and far better than any that would endanger someone in the insecure country or punish those who mine to survive.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media and attention convert your evidence into support — and here, for a fraught nation, the domestic space is constrained and parts of it dangerous, so the "media" that works is the international coverage and the careful documentation that reach the world's interest in Burkina's gold, its pollution, and above all its celebrated land restoration, always safely. The story — a nation of the gold boom and the poisoned water, and of farmers who pushed back the desert — resonates internationally, if told carefully and safely.

Why Media Matters

The functioning institutions, the international bodies, and the world behave differently when the stakes and the harm — and the hope — are visible. Media does three things here: it **connects the world to Burkina's gold pollution and its restoration**, it **raises the support** for cleaner mining and land restoration, and it **reaches the international bodies, the conventions, and the restoration partners**. But the domestic space is constrained and parts dangerous, so the media effort runs through **international coverage, careful documentation, and the safe channels**, protecting everyone, centring on the restorative and the just, and never endangering the poor.

Crafting Your Narrative

Lead with the restoration and the poisoned water. The strongest frame is striking, concrete, and true: *a nation where hundreds of thousands dig for gold to survive while mercury and cyanide seep into the water — and where farmers, with the humble zai pit and the stone bund, have pushed back the desert and brought dead land to life*. Put the pollution and the celebrated restoration first, because the story of a poisoned water and a world-renowned grassroots restoration is striking and resonant, and it frames the effort around cleaning and restoring rather than repressing. Keep it scrupulously accurate and safe; and never endanger anyone in the insecure country or cast the poor as villains. The Burkinabè story is powerful because the pollution is grave, the restoration celebrated, and the justice of helping the poor plain.

Choosing Your Channels

Match the channel to the audience, all careful and safe. **International coverage and documentation** for the world; **the environmental, mining, and restoration media** for the frameworks and experts; **the humanitarian and development channels** for the stakes; and **the community and farmer networks** where safe. Because Burkina's restoration is admired and its pollution grave, the international channels carry the story, the safety of everyone comes first, and the poor are never cast as villains — the poison, the restoration, and the justice are the story's power.

A Few Cautions

Stay accurate, safe, just, and centred on the restorative — the aim is cleaning the gold, sustaining the land, and holding back the desert, framed around the gold, the cotton, and the desert, and never anything that could endanger anyone in the insecure country or punish the poor. Frame the story around the gold, the cotton, the desert, and the water, and handle the military-led government, the politics, the insecurity, and the geopolitics factually and neutrally, keeping the focus on the environment and the restoration. Handle the sensitive matters through the careful international record, never through anything that could endanger a person. And sustain the story across the slow work. Above all, let the poisoned water, the celebrated restoration, and the justice of helping the poor carry the story, because that is where a Burkinabè effort is strongest and safest.

EMAILS & LETTERS: TEMPLATES THAT WORK

Templates save time and prevent mistakes, but adapt every one — insert the real matter, keep it factual, safe, and just, centre on the restorative, and never punish the poor. Here the functioning institutions, the international and mercury and desertification frameworks, the restoration, and the community win. These are addressed to institutions and bodies, not to anyone endangered, and never against the poor.

8A: To a Functioning Institution

Subject: Cleaner methods and formalization at the [site] — protecting water and livelihood

To [environment / mining authority],

We write regarding the mercury and cyanide contamination at [site], which poisons the water while sustaining the livelihood of many. We respectfully urge the cleaner and safer methods, the mercury reduction, the health monitoring, and the formalization in consultation with the miners — protecting both the water and the trade. We attach the evidence.

Respectfully,

[Name / organisation, contact]

8B: The Gold / Cleaner-Mining Case

Subject: Reducing the mercury and cyanide at [area], without repressing the poor

To [mining / environment authority / mercury framework],

The gold sites at [area] use mercury and cyanide that poison the water and land. We respectfully urge the cleaner methods, the mercury and cyanide reduction, and the health monitoring — offered to the miners as safer ways, never as repression. We attach the study.

Respectfully,

[Name / organisation, contact]

8C: The Cotton / Land Case

Subject: Sustaining the cotton and soil at [area]

To [agriculture authority],

The cotton at [area] strains the soil and water with pesticides. We respectfully urge pesticide reduction, integrated pest management, soil health, and support for the smallholder farmers. We attach the data.

Respectfully,

[Name / organisation, contact]

8D: The Desert / Restoration & Green Wall Case

Subject: Holding back the desert at [area] through the proven restoration

To [environment / agriculture authority / Green Wall body],

The land at [area] is degrading to desert. We respectfully urge the spread of the proven grassroots restoration — the zaï pits, the stone bunds, the farmer-managed regeneration — together with the Great Green Wall and agroforestry. We attach the restoration evidence.

Respectfully,

[Name / organisation, contact]

8E: To an International or Convention Body

Subject: Burkina Faso's mercury pollution and desertification — support and frameworks

To [mercury / desertification convention / international body],

We write regarding [the mercury pollution / the desertification] in [area] and respectfully seek the frameworks, the support, and the restoration and mercury-reduction assistance that a fraught state cannot itself provide, in defence of Burkina's water and land. We provide the documentation.

Respectfully,

[Name / organisation, contact]

8F: To a Research or Restoration Body

Subject: Documenting the pollution and spreading the restoration in [area]

Dear [research institute / restoration network],

We write regarding [the pollution / the land degradation] in [area] and respectfully seek your scientific documentation and your restoration knowledge — the monitoring of the harm and the spread of the proven techniques. We provide the documentation.

Respectfully,

[Name, group, contact]

8G: Media / Documentation Pitch

Subject: The poisoned water and the farmers who pushed back the desert

Dear [journalist / editor],

In Burkina Faso, hundreds of thousands dig for gold to survive while mercury and cyanide seep into the water — and farmers, with the humble zaï pit and the stone bund, have pushed back the desert and brought dead land to life. There is a striking, resonant story here of poison and restoration, and we can provide the science, the documentation, and the human stakes, safely and without casting the poor as villains.

Sincerely,

[Name, contact]

8H: To the Community and Farmers

Subject: Our water, our land, our livelihood — let us protect them together

Dear friends,

Our water and land bear the poison of the gold, and the desert presses on our fields — but our own farmers have shown the world how to bring dead land back to life, and there are safer, cleaner ways to win the gold that need not poison us. Together, through what functions and with the world's help, we can clean the gold, protect our water, and restore our land — never by punishing those who dig to eat, but by finding better ways for all. Please join us, safely and together, in defending our water and land and livelihood.

With respect,

[Name / community]

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Sometimes a matter is acute — a contamination spreading from a gold site, a stretch of land degrading fast, a restoration window, a cotton season's pesticide — and you cannot run the full effort. Triage to the levers that work fastest and most safely here, which means the documentation, the functioning institutions and international frameworks, and the community and restoration, protecting people and never punishing the poor.

The First 48 Hours

Establish the essentials: **what is impacted, and what framework reaches it**. Identify the immediate matter — a **contamination, a degrading land, a restoration window, a pesticide** — because that is what you must affect first. Reach the **functioning institutions, the international and mercury or desertification bodies, and the community where safe** at once, because in Burkina Faso the functioning institutions, the international frameworks, and the community and restoration are the fastest routes to real leverage — and keep everyone safe and never target the poor from the start.

The Fastest-Moving Levers

Some levers work faster than others. **The functioning institution** can act on a contamination or restoration within its mandate. **The international and mercury or desertification bodies** can be engaged quickly. **The community and farmer restoration** can move fast where a land is degrading, drawing on proven techniques. **Careful documentation** can capture a contamination quickly. These outpace the slower work

of the deep formalization and the systemic change — which must follow — because the institutions, the international bodies, and the community can be engaged immediately. Above all, if a contamination is spreading, document it and press the functioning institution and the mercury framework for cleaner methods fast — never mere closure that would ruin the poor.

Emergency Coalition-Building

You cannot build a full coalition overnight, but for Burkina Faso you can reach the functioning institutions, the international bodies, and the community and farmers fast, safely, and justly. Reach immediately to the **functioning institutions, the international bodies, and the community and farmers where safe**, protecting everyone and never targeting the poor. A coalition documenting the matter, engaging the functioning institution and the international framework, and mobilising the community and restoration is the most a rapid Burkinabè effort can do. Speed favours the prepared: know the functioning institution, the framework, the restoration, and the safe channels before the crisis breaks, and never punish the poor.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Here, honestly, the field is tilted by a military-led state gripped by an insecurity that makes much of the country dangerous, by a gold economy entangled with conflict and resource-nationalism, by a survival poverty that drives hundreds of thousands to the pits, and by a Sahelian desert and climate that press from beyond. Name it plainly, because pretending the state is secure, or that the gold is easily challenged, or that the poor who mine are villains, would each be false — but the functioning institutions, the international frameworks, and above all the celebrated restoration Burkina's own farmers pioneered make even this tilted field one where careful, safe, restorative, and just work can take hold.

Recognising a Tilted Field

The signs are specific and honest. **The state is military-led** — fraught and resource-nationalist. **Much of the country is insecure** — dangerous in large areas. **The gold is entangled with conflict** — and drives resource-nationalism and smuggling. **The mining is survival poverty** — hundreds of thousands with few alternatives. And **the desert presses from beyond** — climate and drought. But **the functioning institutions, the international frameworks, and the celebrated grassroots restoration** are real levers. This is a tilt of insecurity, entangled gold, and survival poverty, worked through the restoration, the functioning institutions, and the international, protecting people and never punishing the poor, not through confrontation or repression.

Strategies for a Tilted Field

When the field is tilted this way, use the restoration, functioning, and international levers. Lean on the **celebrated grassroots restoration**, the zaï pit and the stone bund that need no strong state and belong to the people; the **functioning institutions**, which retain real capacity where they work; the **international and mercury and desertification frameworks**, which carry leverage and support; the **justice of helping rather than repressing**, which builds legitimacy where repression breeds grievance; and the **community and farmers**, whose knowledge and stake are deep. Meet the insecurity and the entangled gold not with confrontation or repression but with restoration, cleaner methods, and the international frameworks. And build the community, institutional, and international coalition over time, because these accumulate into real, if partial, gains — as the restored hectares show. A field tilted by insecurity and survival poverty is worked through the restoration, the functioning institutions, and the international, protecting people and never punishing the poor.

The Honest Possibility of Losing

You may achieve little against the insecurity and the entangled gold — the pollution may spread, the desert may press, the conflict may worsen — and this guide will not pretend otherwise; the tilt is steep and much is dangerous. But even here the work is rarely wholly wasted, and the restoration is a genuine and proven hope: **the impact was documented, the mercury cut, a site formalized, and above all the land restored** — and every hectare brought back by the zaï and the stone bund, every measure of mercury reduced, every miner helped rather than punished is a real and lasting difference. Press, safely and justly, for the water and the land; even amid the insecurity, the land you help restore and the mercury you help cut are real and lasting goods — for a hectare brought back from the desert feeds a family for generations, and Burkina's own farmers have shown that the desert can indeed be pushed back.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

In Burkina Faso, alongside the honest tilt of insecurity and survival poverty, there is a real dimension of resource-capture and illicit flows, because the gold is now the nation's wealth, and much of it flows through smuggling networks, opaque channels, and in some cases financing linked to armed groups, so there is a genuine risk that the gold's riches serve the powerful, the smugglers, or the armed groups rather than the communities whose water and land it poisons. The harm here is partly the capture of a nation's gold — its wealth flowing to elites, smugglers, or armed groups while the communities bear the poison. The response runs through the transparency, the traceability, the international frameworks, and the just formalization — never the repression of the poor.

Telling Resource-Capture from the Ordinary Tilt

Here the harm is resource-capture and illicit flows, and its marks are specific: **the gold smuggled and its flows opaque, the riches captured by elites, smugglers, or armed groups, the communities bearing the poison while others take the gold, and the formalization used to control rather than to help the poor**. The task is to document it and reach it through the transparency, the traceability, and the international frameworks, relying on the international and research reporting, the trade and smuggling records, and the mercury and mining-governance frameworks, keeping strictly to the environmental and the safe, and never punishing the poor. And note that the same transparency and traceability that expose the illicit flows can help ensure the gold's wealth serves the communities and funds the cleaning of the water and the restoration of the land, and that just formalization — with the miners, not against them — is the honest alternative to both capture and repression.

Responding to Resource-Capture — Through Transparency and the Just Path

Where the resource-capture and illicit flows are real, the response runs through the transparency and the just path. Use the **transparency and traceability and international reporting** to expose where the gold is captured or smuggled and the communities left with the poison. Use the **international and mercury and mining-governance frameworks** to press for the flows to serve the communities and the environment. Use the **just formalization — with the miners, not against them** — as the honest alternative to capture and repression alike. And use the **community's stake** to insist the gold's wealth clean its water and restore its land. Document rigorously, keep strictly to the environmental and the safe, protect everyone, and never punish the poor, for in a fraught nation the record must be careful, the people shielded, and the poor never made the target. Route the effort through the transparency, the traceability, the international, and the just formalization — never through repression that would harm the poor and feed the very insecurity it claims to fight.

A Note on Safety and Protection

This note matters greatly here, and governs everything. Burkina Faso is a fraught, insecure, military-led nation where much of the country is dangerous and armed groups are active, so this work must protect everyone involved, avoid the conflict and armed-group areas, and centre on what is safe — the functioning institutions, the international bodies, and the communities where it is safe. Work through the **functioning-institution, international, and community channels**, and only where it is safe; never expose or endanger anyone, and treat the safety of all involved as the first and overriding consideration; avoid the conflict and armed-group areas entirely; frame the work as the defence of Burkina's water and land, never as a party to the conflict or the politics; and handle the military-led government, the insecurity, and the geopolitics only through the careful international record. And, distinctively here, never make the poor who mine or farm to survive the target: repression of them is unjust, and it feeds the very insecurity it claims to fight. Protection here — of the endangered and of the poor alike — is not one concern among others but the governing rule: the effective, safe, and just path for Burkina Faso runs through the functioning institutions, the international frameworks, the celebrated restoration, and the community, and never through anything that would endanger a person or punish the poor.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps in this guide are written in sequence but run in parallel, each feeding the others — all centred on the restorative and the just, safe, international, community-based, and never punishing the poor. Here is how they fit into a single Burkinabè effort.

The Parallel Effort

From the start, the five run together. **Documentation** builds the impact-and-stakes file. **Target identification** aims it at the restorative and functioning levers. **Local opposition**, understood as the community-farmer-institution-and-international coalition, organises the communities, the farmers, the functioning institutions, and the international bodies. **Regulatory, mining, and land** work cleans the gold, sustains the land, and holds back the desert. **Media**, international and careful, carries the gold-and-land cause. The impact-and-stakes feeds all five at once — a documented matter is a cleaner-mining measure, a restoration, an international appeal, and a community mobilisation together. Run in parallel, they compound; run one at a time, they stall — and here, centred on the restorative and the just and safely, they compound into real, if partial, cleaning of the gold and holding-back of the desert.

A Rough Timeline

Early (weeks 1–8): establish the impact and the stakes; identify the gold, the cotton, the desert, and the water; build the community-farmer-institution-and-international coalition and begin documentation, safely and justly. **Middle (months–years):** clean the gold through cleaner methods and formalization; sustain the cotton and land; hold back the desert through the restoration and the Green Wall; and steward the water and trees. **Later (years):** see the gold cleaned and the mercury cut and the miners helped, the cotton and soil sustained, the desert held back and the land restored, and the water and trees stewarded — real, if partial, outcomes centred on the restoration, in a fraught state, and never at the cost of the poor. A Burkinabè effort works through the functioning institutions, the international, the restoration, and the community; pace it accordingly, and let the safety of everyone and the justice toward the poor govern every step.

The Core Discipline

Through it all, hold the discipline that gives these efforts their force: **document the impact and the stakes; clean and formalize the gold through safer methods and better governance, never repression; sustain the cotton and the land; hold back the desert through the grassroots restoration and the Green Wall; steward the water and the trees; use the functioning institutions, the international, and the community; and protect everyone and never punish the poor.** The coalition that presses all five, centred on the restorative and the just and safely, is the one that can genuinely clean the gold and hold back the desert — the kind of result a fraught, insecure, gold-dependent Sahelian nation allows, through what functions, the restoration, and the international.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Defending the environment in Burkina Faso is genuinely hard, and bound up with a military-led state gripped by insecurity, a gold economy entangled with conflict and resource-nationalism, a survival poverty that drives hundreds of thousands to the pits, and a Sahelian desert and climate that press from beyond, and this guide has been honest about that from its first line: the state is military-led, the country insecure, the gold entangled with conflict, the mining a survival livelihood, and no swift victory exists. And yet the effort is far from futile, because Burkina Faso is home to some of the world's most celebrated grassroots land restoration — so the gold can be cleaned through safer methods and just formalization, the cotton and land can be sustained, the desert can be held back through the restoration its own farmers pioneered, the water and trees can be stewarded, and the functioning institutions and the international and community channels offer real avenues even a fraught state affords; and those levers of the gold, the cotton, the desert, the water, and the channels are real.

Some honest truths hold across every effort here. **Burkina's farmers pioneered world-renowned restoration — the desert can be pushed back. The gold is the economy and a survival livelihood, so it is cleaned, never repressed. The state is fraught and much insecure, so the work is through what functions and safely. And the poor who mine are never the target — repression is unjust and self-defeating.** Hold both truths at once: real, distinctive, hopeful levers of the restoration, the functioning institutions, and the international, and the honest weight of a military-led state, an entangled gold, and a survival poverty.

Above all, keep the discipline — and the safety and the justice — that give these efforts their force. Document the impact and the stakes. Clean and formalize the gold through safer methods and better governance, never repression. Sustain the cotton and the land. Hold back the desert through the grassroots restoration and the Green Wall. Steward the water and the trees. Use the functioning institutions, the international, and the community. And protect everyone and never punish the poor — because in a fraught, insecure, gold-dependent Sahelian nation, an effort that cleans the gold, sustains the land, and holds back the desert, centred on the restoration and the just and keeping everyone from harm, is the one that is both effective and just.

Burkina Faso is a landlocked Sahelian nation, a land of gold and cotton and hard-won soil, military-led and gripped by insecurity, where hundreds of thousands dig for gold to survive while mercury and cyanide seep into the water, and where, against the encroaching desert, its own farmers have pushed back the sands with the humble zai pit and the stone bund. This guide has hidden none of that — the fraught state, the insecurity, the entangled gold, the survival poverty — and there is no swift or landmark victory to promise you. But Burkina Faso holds a hope that shames far richer nations: the celebrated grassroots land restoration by which its people turned dead ground back into cropland and forest, a proven, low-cost practice that belongs to the communities themselves. Those are the levers, and they are real: the cleaner

methods and the mercury reduction and the just formalization that can clean the gold without punishing the poor; the pesticide reduction and soil health that can sustain the cotton and land; the zaï pits and stone bunds and the Great Green Wall that can hold back the desert; and the water harvesting, reforestation, and agroforestry that can steward the water and trees. There is no strong state to rely on, no easy challenge to the gold, and no work that is not shadowed by the insecurity; this guide has said so throughout, and insisted above all on the safety of everyone and on never punishing the poor. But the water and the land of Burkina Faso are worth every careful, safe, just, restorative effort, the levers that run through the restoration, the functioning institutions, and the international are real, and the patient, protective, just work of cleaning the gold, sustaining the land, holding back the desert, and stewarding the water is one that the communities, the farmers, the functioning institutions, and the international bodies can genuinely do — as the farmers who stopped the desert have already shown the world. So can you.